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From the Editor in Chief's desk:

By Swami Paranand Tirth

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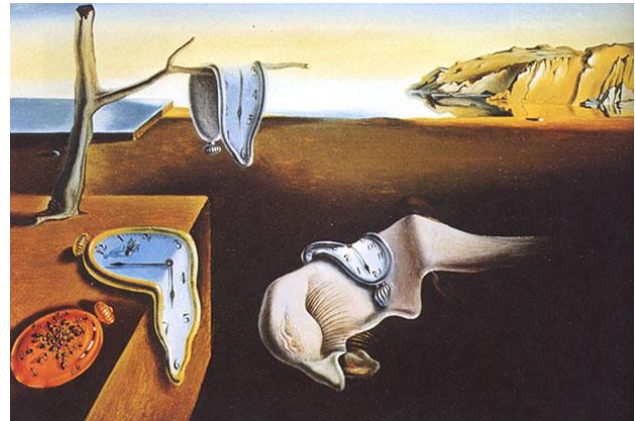


From the chief editors desk ..

On Predating and Outlasting Time

सदेव सोम्य इदमग्रआसीत्

O! Benign one existence alone prevailed in the beginning! an enlightened seer instructs his rather indolent son. The pupil is not in a position to correlate time transcendent and absolute notions. So for the sake of conveying to him he uses the conflicting notion सत् that is



The Persistence of Memory by Salvador Dali, 1931
(<http://uk.phaidon.com/agenda/art/articles/2016/may/10/salvador-dali-the-persistence-of-memory-explained/>)

“existent and time transcendental” entity. “Existent and Eternity” must be timeless notions. To be existent and eternal an entity must be beyond all the three time dimensions i.e. past, present and future. There has to be an absence of these three time dimensions.

Anything conditioned in these three tenses has been called *mithya* or virtual in discursive Vedanta. Whatever is virtual or transitory must have a real substratum even for its appearance - that appearance is real or let's say reality itself. The truth predates time and outlasts it. All other relative notions are subject to their ephemeral, transitory and momentary disposition hence the identification with the essential nature is inevitable .

To identify oneself with real nature costs everything .Everything as it were comprises everything else besides the essential nature –or the subjective substratum. The knowledge of essential nature fails to dawn owing to the erroneous identity which is why there is so much emphasis on discriminatory wisdom and dispassion in the traditional lineage of self realization. Discrimination between the ephemeral and eternal is one of the four requisites for self realization. In fact absolute dispassion from the ephemeral and objective phenomena has to be inculcated. It is only after ascertaining the eternity as one's essential nature gained through faith and devotion as well as intuitive insight generated by them that one gets established in his essential nature (which is beyond time conditioning).

Enlightenment is not something that happens in some time fraction. Emancipation literally is transcending the relative time notion. The instant of epiphany lies within the domain of conditioned awareness. Time, space, material conditioning and the aberrant identification with produces of this conditioning, leads to a perpetuated quagmire of misgivings. Just as a man cannot lift himself up by pulling his shoe strings no upaya can lead an aspirant out of this plight. Hence one must resort to *Mahasahas* or the great venture to transcend the concomitant trail of cause and effect. The instant of crossing the threshold of time conditioning and the time transcendental lies within the time conditioned portion of the phenomena. The preceding time fraction, the present one and the next time

fraction are all the eternal word and its innate meaning.

One of the most popular Vedic hymn *says all this that was and will be is **purusa** alone . The past the present and the future is all *Om* besides whatever lies beyond time is also "Om", says the smallest but highly significant canon of metaphysics -Mandukya Upanisad. There can be no rational order of succession in the phenomena of the awareness switching between the time conditioned and time transcendental modes. This so much coveted Swarup or essential nature is defined as spontaneous and innate and therefore not an ideation or conceptualization.

Since it is also the universal self there is no recess for any admixture of nescience and its products, nothing can supersede it, being all transcendental there can be nothing more subtler and pervasive than this . The swarup or essential nature is limitless and owing to its perfect homogeneity and all pervasiveness there is no space for any form of displacement, exterior or internal .There is absolutely no space and time conditioning in the self so rhetorically speaking there are no boundaries and thus no abode.

What one understands as "freedom" can be possible only from a spiritual perspective. In the eastern metaphysics liberation, emancipation or *moksha* which follows self realization have been the most cherished objectives of human life. They have been called

पुरुषार्थ or परमपुरुषार्थ in the eastern culture.

Despite the omissions and commissions of indulgences in the Tantras, the sine qua non of moderation and dispassion cannot be denied. You cannot enter the kingdom of heaven bag and baggage.

Exalted with the ecstatic bliss of self realization, the pupil of Astavakra king Janaka upon realizing his absolutely detached and all pervasive nature says-

अहो अहं नमो मह्यं यस्य मे नास्ति किंचन अथवा य
स्यमे सर्वे यत्किंचित्सचराचरम्

O what a wonder I am! .Obeisance to myself!
who possess nothing or possess everything all
that is on the earth.

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Editorial



The path to discovery of ‘True Self’ or the essential nature is strewn with multiple obstacles, most of which are the self created ones. The anchors like identity, ego and worldly ties to which we hold on with all our might come across as hindrances on this path. While there are blissful moments of floating along with the current, these are often interrupted when the path starts to defy our sense of reason. When it sounds illogical and more so when it hurts our limited ego we are completely at loggerheads with it.

There are times when doubt starts filling our heart and in a vain attempt to understand what is not to be understood we find ourselves back at ground zero. There have been times when aspirants have totally given up the path to stick to familiar grounds. It is here that a true aspirant needs to summon the divine mother to help him/her cross the obstacles and this can be achieved with the help of a Guru.

Explaining the idea of true freedom and the identification with one's essential and eternal nature in the Editorial our Guru maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirthji stresses on the importance given to this enlightenment in various traditions of Indian metaphysics. The knowledge of essential nature fails to dawn owing to the erroneous identity which is why there is so much emphasis on discriminatory wisdom and

dispassion in the traditional lineage of self realization.

Next we have Swamiji's enlightening article ‘Wisdom from Shiva's Rattle drum’ dealing with ‘Monism from a grammarian's perspective. Creation as word and meaning, also called as shabdi and arthi sristi in the agamic canons, remains in a perfect homogeneity with its meaning and this transcendental form of vak being indistinguishable from pure subjective consciousness comprises the substratum which is the monistic absolute principle. Citing examples from various texts Swamiji explains the purport of Nandikeshvara's aphorism.

This is followed by Niraj Kumar's insightful paper on ‘Mathematical Pattern in Sriyantra’. He writes, ‘Sriyantra appears as a bilaterally symmetrical and geometrical. The central triangle that emerges out of intersection is an equilateral triangle.’ The formation of this mystic triangle which is not drawn has been the focus of the paper and this the author believes holds the key for future mathematics.

Next we have the first part of the travelogue ‘Southern Sojourns’ by Dr G.L. Kaw, narrating the author's latest visit to South Indian temples. This illustrated and detailed narrative provides a very handy information for future pilgrims with apt references to the historical and legendary incidences.

This is followed by two poems by Ambika Talwar full of spiritual quest and longing. The first poem ‘Sacred lodge for Beloveds’ would remind one of mystic love poetry written by various poets who have given words to their eternal longing.

In the end we have a photo feature on the temples of Cambodia by Deepak Kaw who has

captured some beautiful and poetic views of these temples during his visit.

(Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher is Asst. Professor at Amity School of Fine Arts (ASFA) and teaches History of Art, Aesthetics and Art Criticism)

WISDOM FROM SHIVA'S RATTLED DRUM .

एओंग - ३

E" ong

MONISM FROM A GRAMMARIAN'S
PERSPECTIVE the doctrine of
Shabdadvaitam .

Swami Paranand Tirth

Key words

*Purism . Descriptive linguist . Ishwaradwaitam
sphota. Shiv Tulyah , Panchikaranam,
.Anthropocentricity . Mhavakyam. Vyahritis.
The sun of reason . Kutasth. Kalilavastha.
Chaos .*

Abstract:

*Creation defined as word and meaning . The
word that was in the beginning . Metaphysical
wisdom encrypted in the fourth beat . Sphota
as the origin of word and meaning . The other
portion interpreted as Omkar -the essence of
the Vedas . The Vedic process of expansion of
Omkara into vyahriti , Gayatri and the three
Vedas . The unity of name and form . The
pronounceable and unpronounceable aspects
of Omkara . Universal vision of the perfect
being remains the same whether creation is
there or not .*

The ancient school of Indian Purism maintains that one word without a second predates the process of creation which in its basic mode is ideal and conceptual. Creation in this parlance is a divergent out flux of the separation of word and meaning.

Creation as word and meaning ,also called as shabdi and arthi sristi in the agamic canons ,remains in a perfect homogeneity with its

meaning and this transcendental form of vak being indistinguishable from pure subjective consciousness comprises the substratum which is the monistic absolute principle. An ancient school of thought in descriptive linguistic is akin to the monosyllabic dingdong theory of the origin of word[1]* .This has its root in the ancient dictum of the Brahmins –ekakshara vai vak *{ speech is monosyllabic } that leads to an arcane tradition in which each one of the alphabet is related to a specific ontology of the elements and their homogeneity .

There is yet another mystic tradition in which each of the syllable corresponds to a specific numeral –this however is not in vogue any more

This tradition of a singular monistic substratum which blends with the doctrine of ishwaradwaitam has been encrypted in the aphorism ‘ai ong’ . This as per the tradition of the agamic lineage stands in no need of conventional deciphering since the agamas demand a strict subservience to the dictum of the preceptor when it comes to mystic decoding of these aphorisms . Nandikeshwara in this context was the recipient of the latent metaphysical exposition, therefore besides the omniscient lord he is the next preceptor . The tradition of discursive interpretation of this sutra also explains the propound of the entire science of the “word” or *shabda Brahman* .

Sphotas is the name given to the *quantas* of conveyance of word and the power of consciousness which accounts for the unison of word with its meaning . There are eight odd variations of sphota .viz alphabet, word, sentence , alphabet and word, word and sentences all these and these four as one by one and four as whole. The votaries of letter, word etc. or sentence as the expression of sphotas have dogmatic disputes and usually do not fall in with one another. Kaiyata, the propounder of “sentence as the sphota” also maintains the absolute Brahman as the primordial word”- The absolute Brahman also manifests as the primordial word and He conditioned in the

virtual superimposition comes to be called as matter or material (*dravya*).

Kaiyata is justified in as much as his accepting the dictum of the revelations that “All this is verily atman”. All virtual superimpositions stand denied as opposed to the one without a second nature of Atman. Hence the denuded, unveiled eternal element of word is definitely proclaimed as only the imperishable Akshara- Obeisance to the complete one ! (Vaikaran Bhushan Sar of Kaund Bhatt)

In the lineage of Kashmir Slavism there are three traditions viz siva to *skanda*, *shiva* to *devi* and *shiva* to Nandikeshwara the celestial bull vehicle of lord shiva .This gloss of Nandikaeshawara on the shaivite aphorism may have some relevance in the development of the Kashmir shaivism specially in one of its three offshoots usually known as *ishwara dwaitam* . The main propound of the commentary on this aphorism is the unity of maheshwara with the universal phenomena . Since there is no notion of a virtual superimposition of the universal phenomena on the substratum of subjective consciousness ,this unity is not from the standpoint of rejecting the objective phenomena but by asserting maheshwara as interlaced in the phenomena and also as transcending it. This however does conflict the dual and multiple notion of shiva and the admission of similarity or *shiv tulyatwam* [*shiv tulyo jayate*].

The vedic notion of shiva is universally acknowledged as

Eon mahesvarav aikyam vijnanam sarvavastusu Saksitvat sarvabhutanam sa eka iti niscitam

This aphorism propounds the unity of maheshwara and its gnosis in all beings .owing to his witness nature he must be singular entity since rationally there can be no two witnesses in a metaphysical parlance . With regard to {the sutra} eon: ‘a’ is imperishable, ‘i’ is united with Maya [and] being so [it becomes] ‘u’ which has the form of knowledge, omniscient by nature. Oneness of all things [and] absence of multiplicity and relationships such as between

creator and created leads to non-dualism. He himself having entered [the world] assumed its form. Just as a Banyan tree seed, so also a group of five letters appearing in first two sutras become the cause [or the seed] of the entire universe [or universe with form], This was declared. The letters in the subsequent sutras also originate from those [five letters]. This sutra is an aggregate, or a conjunction [samyoga] of the third letter with the first and the second letter with the first through distinct relationship of the whole and a part [= samastivyasti]. The connection [sambandha] was also said to exist in oneness.

*In a text called Sanak Daxinamurti samvada or the dialogue between Sanak and Daxinamurthi the lord confines to Sanaka as follows ,

(This daxina murti sanak camvad ‘ is taken from a version Nandikeshwar kashika/karika . uploaded on the net by some anonymous source – in russain and roman characters . the original scripture is not traceable .)

“Listen attentively about equality of all four Vedas. The great sayings [or Upanisads] consisting of four [statements] are spoken here in this world. Whatever is expressed by the word *Brahma* , it is said to be omniscience (or wisdom, or intelligence). Tat (That) refers to Brahma because [he is] the witness of all, so Tat tvam asi (you are that) is the only truth. The difference [of sayings] is for the purpose of distinction between Vedic schools. [The saying] ‘ayam atma.....’ (this Self....) belongs to the Atharva Veda.”

The primordial eternal word is in fact a singular and uperishable syllable that predates both types of creations i.e. word and meaning . Omkara or Pranav has also been claimed to mean just what the Mahavakyas do. The essence of the four Vedas are their upanisads or the compendium of metaphysics .Their main propound is the unity of the empirical and universal soul which is also the meaning of this great syllable .The three portions of the omkra i.e. A U and M are interpreted as meaning both cosmic as well as the invidual states of vishwa virat,aijas

hiranyagarbh and prajna ishwara respectively .
Sadashiv brahmendra the famous enlightened
author of Kiranavali a commentary on the great
five precept by adi shankara has opined with the
view of unity of the meaning of pranav
and mahvakyas .

प्रणवः सर्व वेदानां सारतत्त्वप्रकाशते

तेन चित्तसमाधानं मुमुक्षूणा विधीयते

Pranavah sarv vedanaam sar tatwam

prachakshate

Ten chittasamadhanam

mumukshoonamvidheeyate .

Oamkara has been described as the essence of
all Vedas . Some thinkers interpret this in a
different way .Aum is the essence of three
vyahritis viz. bhu, bhuvah and swah . these
three further expand into the three portions of
the gayatri which has been eulogized as the
mother of the Vedas. Three portions of the
gayatri in turn expand into the three Vedas i.e.
rik, yaju and sama . There was an ancient
school of Vedanta called shabd brahm vada in
which by repeating only the omkara one recited
all the four Vedas.

The sectarian version of Adi Shankaras school
of thought maintains that the essence of the four
Vedas is the mahavakyam since the essence is
not understood in terms of concision but
according to purport of the revelation which in
this parlance is the unity of the empirical self
with the universal self .In this school of thought
the essence of the Vedas taken as one by one is
their mahavakyas – the great dictums which
further tallies with the meaning of the essence
of the Vedas according to the ancient school
of *shabd brahamvad* which propounds that the
primordial word of god or omkara was the
substratum of the entire expression audible as
well as conceived.

Nandikeshwara propounds this to be the arcane
meaning of the aphorism ‘ai ong’ which he
construes to mean omkara after relating the
bindu or anuswara from the previous aphorism.
vishwam virat rupaen pashyt bhed
nivrittaye says Sureshwaracharya in his

commentary on Panchikaranam. This unity may
or may not be actual since the great critic says
this should be done in order to remove duality .
Nevertheless the unity as the propound of the
great syllable pranav and that of the
mahavakyas remains unquestionable . Therefore
Nandikeshwara’s interpretation of the sutra
एऔंग also aims at the innate and per se unity of
the individual soul with the universal .

Nandikeshwara maintains that the seed syllable
of all the four Vedas, omkara is latent in this
aphorism unlike other pronounced or
conceived words. The word and meaning
relationship is innate and inseparable in this
syllable . *This means abhidhan[name] and*
abhidhey[form] are not separable in this syllable
.Owing to its transcendental nature this word
belongs to the realm of para vak in which the
word and meaning are in perfect homogeneity .
The innate unison of *abhidhana and*
abhidheya rules out any admission of cause and
effect in this parlance and therefore there is no
taint of duality .

There are three different connotations of omkara
according to the three Vedas .In this aphorism
the Atharvana pranava i.e.ओं - the one with one
connotation is relevant .Some confuse this one
with the fourteenth vowel with a nasal accent
but this is not feasible here since the omkara is
supposed to be permeating or rather pervading
the entire expressible speech .Just as the
reticulum or veins pervade a leaf all speech is
pervaded by *omkara* [upanisad]*

The pertinence of three portions of the syllable
as referring to each of the three Vedas seems to
be a later concept . In the beginning there must
have been a single uninterrupted eternal word of
god from which transient fragments of syllable
with a beginning and end sprang forth . As one
theory of the eternity of word goes, the
preceeding syllable must perish and give way to
the consequent one for the continuation of
expression. This is inconsistent in this parlance
.There fore an arcane exposition has demarked
two notions of omkara as *savada* and *avada* .

The former is pronounced and as soon as the effort of the vocal apparatus required to pronounce it finishes it comes to an end . On the other hand the avada or the unspeakable one resonate eternally and needs no deliberate pronunciation. This is a great revelation of the hoary seers which takes the omnipresence of god expressible by this syllable beyond the confinements of anthropocentricity .It is about this mode of omkara that the Tandya Brahman says “vak is monosyllabic ,and thus eternal” some dotrines also use the term akhanda or unfragmented instead of ananta both are one and the same notion except the viewpoints the former is spatial and the latter one refers to absence of limit and a perpetuated continuity . Hence the difference between the fourteenth vowel with a nasal accent and the real pranav is conspicuous .

One of the eminent monist seers, Sadashiv brahmendra has tried to establish the synonymy of omkara and the great dictums of the upanisads.In his short treatise Kiranavali which is rather a gloss on the upadeshpanchakam of Adi shankaracharya, Sadashiv Brahmendra attributes a considerable portion in providing arguments in support of his postulation . Nandikeshwara however gives only the universal witnessing nature as an argument in support of his specification .Since there cannot be dual or plural witness as per the reasoning followed by Shankarite monists He is one without a second -this fact stands well established .

There is an interesting specification in the tantras –

ग्राह्यग्राहकसंवित्ति सामान्यं सर्व देहिनाम्
योगीनांतुविशेषोस्मिन्विषये सावधानता ।

The experience of subjective and objective stimulus is common place in all sentient being . but yogins have a special viewpoint in this respect . What is usually experienced as ‘this ‘ or this ness by a commoner who due to ignorance conceives of himself as a body his perspective of the objective experience is finite and most of the times aberrant .A yogi on the

other hand has various standpoints as a gross physical body ,as identifying himself with his senses , mind , reason, or spirit . Pratyabhijna hridayam says this universal phenomena comprising thirty six elementary constituents of the phenomena is multiiferous owing to various gradations of experience and experiencer . The ultimate seer is shiva or anuttara when he “sees” the seen or the scene is the entire phenomena from shakti to earth . Shakti is merely a divergent aspect of shiva when she sees , the seen is from sadashiva to earth and sadashiva is the one who is seen by shakti and shiva as well becomes the seer of the rest of the phenomena from ishvara to earth . This gradation of seer and seen changes proportionally but the ultimate seer or the sakshi who is also translated as the ultimate witnessing awarenss remains to be shiva . Taken as not different from the guru or deshika ,maheshwara nath felicitates Him or rather his universal vision as

कलिलावस्थायांदेशिकवर्यस्य यावान्प्रसरः

विश्वोन्मेषदशायामपि तावान्भवति ।

The extent of the holy preceptors or shivas vison in a state when the entire phenomena is dormant is one and the same.The primordial “chaos” remains the same even after the universal manifestation has fully expanded and is still expanding . This is to assert that shiv drishti or the vision of the complete being is not conditioned by the process of unfolding of the universal phenomena .

Nandikeshwara vindicates his ” one without a second “ disposition of maheshwara by the argument of being the sole witness of all relative gradations of experiences and objects of experiences.

There are pairs of relative objective and subjective experiences but the main stream line of awareness of primary subjective awareness that interlaces the multifarious permutations and combinations of of grahya and grahaka .the ultimate witness must be one without a second and thus paramshiva . He is also the universal self the self of all sentient creatures . One

doesn't have to be an erudite scholar of the Vedas to know this –the veda itself proclaims

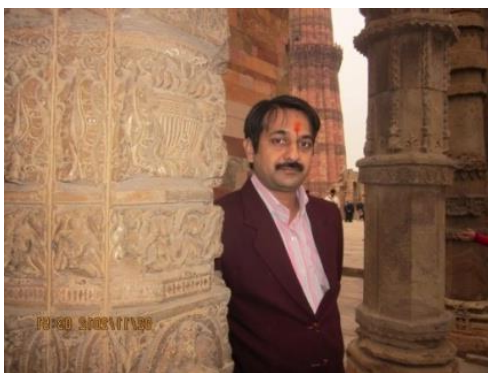
उतैनंगोपाअह्नदृशन्नुदहार्यः स दृष्टोमृडयातिनः

(यजुर्वेद)

“Even illiterate cowboys saw him, rural dames carrying water pots on their head saw him too may the seer who has become the ‘seen’ grant us happiness.”

This mantra is about the sun god who is conventionally considered as the universal seer or in fact the sole seer of the entire phenomena consisting of movable and immovable creatures. The “sun of reason” as the mystic hermits of Philokalia call him is the sole witness of all cognitive functions individually as well as collectively. In the eastern metaphysics this sun of reason has been termed as चित्सूर्य or the sun of consciousness . The gloss of Nandikeshwar refers to this singular entity whose singularity is supported by the reasoning that he is the only witness. In Vedanta we have a term called *kutasth* or the indweller non indulgent witness. Just as a man sitting on top of a hill watching a river flowing below observes many things flowing in its current , good ,bad agreeable disagreeable ,dirt and holy leaf- cups with lamps burning it them a good looking lad swimming a corpse so on and so forth . The *kutastha* [–lit . a man situated on top of the hill] is neither tainted nor indulges . A silent witness who is beyond all that he transcends is what is meant by *sakshitwam sarva bhutanam* .By the very virtue of being *sakshi* or witness he turns out to be the one without a second. Rationally the ultimate witness must be a single ,monistic absolute entity . This witnessing nature as we have said above while citing from Maharth manjari does not refer only to the creation but also its a posteriori i.e. dissolution which as the cyclic course of events would have it alternate . *kalilavastha* is the state of chaos [a term for *avyaktam* in ancient Greek philosophy } or the un-manifest .This is essentially a supra mundane entity . Witnessed by the absolute principle who is ever existent independently without requiring any presence or

absence of the universal manifestation for the vindication of his existence .



Mathematical Pattern in Sriyantra

Niraj Kumar

The Sriyantra emerges out of interlocking of 9 triangles. There is a symmetric pattern generated by this interlocking of isosceles triangles. The nine prime triangles have 27 points. The triangle represents three fires-sun, moon and the earthly fire. Astronomically, triangle represents the close relationship between three cosmic bodies-Earth, Sun and the Moon. Nine triangles correspond to nine planets in Hindu astronomy and 27 points to the 27 asterisms(nakshatra).

The Sri Yantra is drawn from nine triangles, four pointed upward are the Shiva triangles also known as *Srikanthas* and five pointed downward are the Shakti triangles or the *Shivayuvatis*. These intersect and interlock to form 43 small triangles around a central small triangle. Such interlocking of triangles that produce many times more the number of primary triangles is extraordinary. In India, triangle became iconic signifier of the Shakti principle, the dynamic aspect of Creation. Sriyantra though involves different geometrical shapes like circle and square, it is the triangular shape which is predominant.

The design crops up with only 8 triangles, four upwards and 4 downwards as these pair. The ninth triangle does not interlock with any triangle. It is independent. It is the fifth Shakti triangle with apex pointing downward within

whose womb the innermost equilateral triangle is generated. In this inner most triangle, the altitudes, the angle bisectors, the perpendicular bisectors and the medians to each side coincide at midpoint, which is represented as bindu(dot). The Bindu is in-centre also since this is also the centre of the circle which encloses the bunch of triangles. The fifth triangle is supposed to interlock with the bindu. Bindu is the abode of the Goddess of Srividya, Ma Lalita. The three corners of the fifth triangle are considered to be the abode of Three Mahadevis—Mahakali, Mahalaskhmi and Mahasaraswati. This triangle is also known as the Trikona, the bestower of all siddhis.

This central equilateral triangle has played the most interesting role in the evolution of the Sriyantra into a crown-mandala. In human bodies, eight holes are in symmetry. Two eyes, two ears, two nostrils are in bilateral symmetry. The mouth and the organ of evacuation are in transversal symmetry, with mouth being the upper orifice for entering of food and the downward orifice its mirror image for evacuation of the waste. But, it is the ninth hole which is not interlocked with its other in human body. The ninth orifice interlocks with external “other”, that creates *yamal*, conjugal pair. Thus, the interlocking of 8 triangle and leaving aside ninth triangle does correspond to orificial position of human body. Interestingly, this ninth circle is the source of creation, both in the male and the female body. The ninth triangle generates the inner most equilateral triangle as the creatrix which become the emanation triangle in the Sriyantra.

Inner Equilateral Triangle

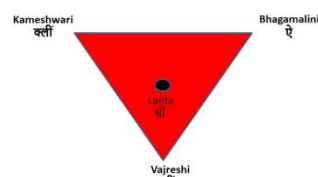


Figure 1: Innermost Triangle of Sriyantra

The Bindu contains the potentiality of the universe within itself. Bindu too is believed to be consisting of three aspect called Nada, Kala and Bindu . Here, father and mother aspect-Varahi and Kurukulla- is represented through two drops- red and white. The third drop is the mixture. Thus central bindu itself has a triadic aspect. At the centre of the bindu is Kamakala, which has three bindus. One is red, one is white and one is mixed. The red bindu is Kurukulla the Female form, the white bindu is Varahi the Male form, and the mixed bindu is the union of Shiva & Shakti , our own human body as the Shri Cakra, as discussed earlier. Varahi, the father-form, gives four dhatus to the child and Kurukulla, the mother-form, gives five dhatus to the child. These represent the nine dhatus of the human body[(seven dhatus of human body in ayurveda are chile/plasma(rasa), blood(rakta), flesh(mamasa), fat(meda), bone(asthi), marrow(majja), semen(sukra)]. Hair and skin were added since these two also grow from the food and support body. These are also known as nine gems, navaratna and described in the Chapter V of the Tantraraja Tantra.

Varahi's four fires are the 12 (4 x 3) Sun Kalas, the 12 zodiac constellations. Kurukulla's five triangles are the 15 (5 x 3) Kalas of the moon, or the 15 lunar Tithis. Similar thinking is also seen in the Kalacakra Tantra .

Basic structure of Meru in Sriyantra



Figure 2: Traditional Drawing of Sriyantra

Now, the whole structure can be looked differently, as stated it is context-specific. Let us have a cursory look at the different enclosures first, before we develop into its mathematical properties.

The 14-sided polygon is formed with the intersection of 8 triangles(as stated, ninth is independent) which contains 43 triangles . It is enclosed within a circle. The circle may signify the chakra, the eternal movement of Kala under which the whole manifestation is bound. There is an 8 petals enclosure on the circumference of the circle. Surrounding the 8 petal sheath is a 16 petal circle. Then there is another trinity, concentric 3 circles(trivalaya) and at the outermost part,there are 3 lines forming a square called the Bhupura. There are gates on each side of the bhupura. The space between the sides of the square and the circumference of the outermost circle, is known as Trailokya Mohana Chakra, the Enchanter of the Triple World. Nine chakras of Sriyantra that emerge after intersection of nine triangles are as follows:

1. Trailokya Mohana Chakra—space between outer square and inner three concentric circle
2. Sarvasa Paripuraka Chakra – 16 Petals
3. Sarva Sanksobhana Chakra– 8 Petals
4. Sarva Saubhagyadayaka Chakra – 14 Triangles [Chaturdasa Kona]
5. Sarvartha Sadhaka Chakra – 10 Triangles [Outer Dasara]
6. Sarva Raksakara Chakra – 10 Triangles [Inner Dasara]
7. Sarva Rogahara Chakra – 8 Triangles [Ashta Kona]
8. Sarva Siddhiprada Chakra –Downward Secondary Triangle
9. Sarvanandamaya Chakra – Bindu – Full of all Bliss.

It is interesting to observe that the whole geometric figure is encapsulated within trinities. The central diagram is determined by the

triangles, but other sheaths are also following the Rule of Three. The outer square has three lines, the outer concentric circles are three. Thus, even though other geometrical figures are involved, three as a number determines their positioning. I would like to further add that this Trinitarian nature extends to the tradition as a whole.

Mathematical Properties

Sriyantra appears as a bilaterally symmetrical and geometrical. The central triangle that emerges out of intersection is an equilateral triangle. The two largest up and down triangles are drawn such that these touch the circle. There are 18 three line crossing points. Apex of every triangle touches the base of another triangle, while two biggest triangles, one up and down each touch the circumference of enclosing circle at three points. Equilateral inner triangle brings inner asymmetry, though equilateral triangle itself is highly symmetric. Rest of the primary triangles are isosceles triangles, but they bring the symmetry of the fringes. This is quite paradoxical. There is no diameter, but the diameter appears by linking all the apex of 9 triangles. Across the diametric division passing through the apex, it is symmetric; else in all kinds of division, it is asymmetric.

In my opinion, this reveals another esoteric aspect that symmetry is established only at the peak points. Whatsoever is the level, or the sheath, the peak makes the way for equanimity, one can see the world with equanimity and poise, and the cycle of karma ceases. Sriyantra is thus both symmetric and asymmetric.

Sriyantra has central vertex. 9 triangles have 27 vertices, that correspond to the nakshatrachakra (27 nakshatras). Number 27 itself is significant as it is obtained by another multiplication of 9 with 3. Total number of

points in the figure comes out to be 51 (27 vertices of primary triangles + 24 points of the petals). This corresponds to 51 pithas, 51 alphabets in the Yogini Hridaya.

Though, the triangles form a regular 14-sided polygon, the total number of triangles that emerge is 43. This number falls in the series of Metallic Mean.

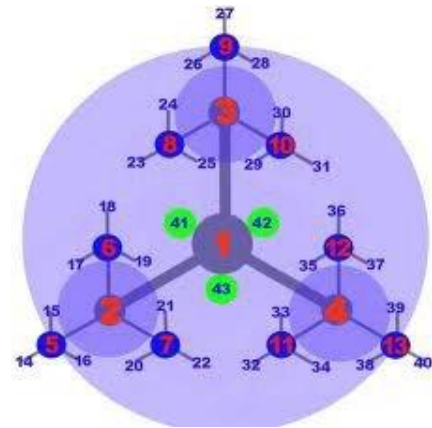


Figure 3: The Ternary Tree of 43

<http://hans.wyrdweb.eu/tag/sri-yantra/>

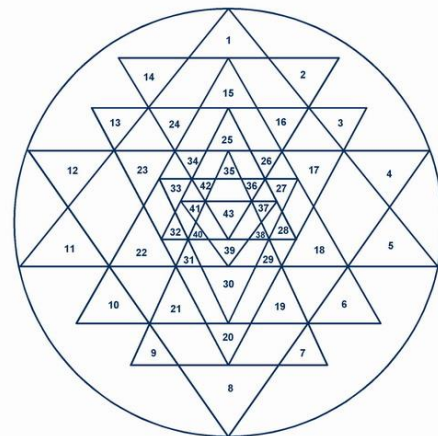


Figure 4 43 triangles in Sriyantra

<http://aspenmoonart.com/sri-yantra-explored/sriyantra43count/>

43 triangles itself brings to the fore the perfect trinitization of the geometrical figure as depicted above. The single triangle undergoing three layers of trinitization creates 43 triangles.

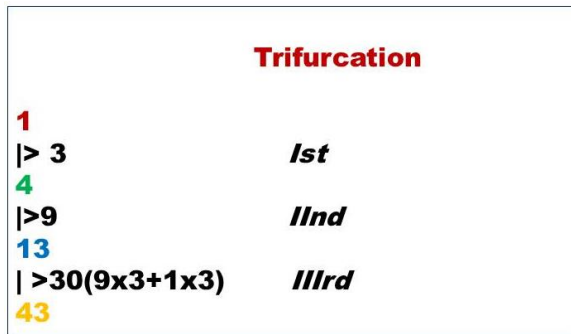


Figure 5: Scale of trifurcation for 43

This is known as Balanced Ternary Tree structure in algorithm. Now, the engineers are trying to use this algorithm in the computer programming. The Ternary-tree representation (Figure 3) for efficient parallel computation on binary trees has been successfully simulated by the Japanese computer engineers and they are claiming that the ternary logic will replace binary logic in the CPUs in future. The number 43 is being recognized with the infinite potentiality, not only in technology but also in unravelling the mystery of the Universe

The Sriyantra has a very high level of concurrency. Dick Tahta, the famous mathematician who taught Stephen Hawking and who was instrumental in establishing branch of ethno-mathematics concluded that , “the central design of the Sriyantra consists of nine isosceles triangles, intersecting in a surprisingly complex pattern of collinearities.”

Alexander Kulaichev who was the first to work on the mathematical properties of Sriyantra in 1984 concluded that:

“The whole Sriyantra seal may now be described by system of algebraic non-linear equation. From the geometrical nature of the system, it may be presumed that there is at least one real solution(root), which may be calculated by some iterative method.”

Kulaichev tried to describe Sriyantra seal by system of algebraic non-linear equation from second to sixteenth power of variable.

He was surprised that what “sort of representational means and knowledge had been used for reproduction of the Sriyantra seal during centuries?” and “ How the idea of nine triangles consolidating in such polygon with precise matching of numerous points of intersection arose?” Kulaichev posits for “possibility of existence of unknown cultural and historical alternative of mathematical knowledge e.g. highly developed tradition of the special imagination” ,in India after his thorough study of the mathematical properties.

The triangles itself can be seen as two-fold-primary triangles and secondary triangles which are created due to the combinatorial properties of interlocking primary triangles. The recursion of triangles appear as if all triangles are constructed separately, though it is only the result of the interlocking. Thus, in one way, though there are fractal properties of recursion of same pattern, it is not the exact fractal of determinate dimensions, since the triangles appear out of intersection and are not the drawn images. Here, smaller triangles are secondary repetitions generated by interlocking of primary repetitions of similar shape. Thus, 43 smaller triangles can be termed as cognate triangles in mathematical terms.

Patrick Flanagan(1991) discovered another interesting feature in the diagram. The first up-triangle in Sriyantra is exact cross- section of the geometry of the Great Pyramid of Gaza. If $\frac{1}{2}$ its base is one unit, its height is equal to the square root of the Golden section ,Phi (Φ). The two sides of the triangle are equal to Phi as it is an isosceles triangles. Phi is a rudimentary fractal and causes inter-nesting and recursion in innumerable phenomena, particularly in biology like phyllotaxis and tissue arrangements.

Shri Yantra contains 43 triangles. This number emerges in the series of Bronze mean. One must remember how Phi, the golden mean that

emerges as the solution in the Fibonacci sequence, itself derivable from Meru Prastara, is a continued fraction itself, and also associated with Sriyantra. Bronze mean is a generalization of the sequence of Fibonacci based on trinity. The onus is now on the shoulders of mathematicians to find the Bronze Mean equation of the Sriyantra.

relationship among triangles within. For the sake of brevity, I am putting up the dimensions from three Sriyantras. The Table 1 measures the size of different triangles etc. of the Sriyantra figure was published by *Indian Journal of History of Sciences* (C.S.Rao(1998). Sriyantra-A Study of Spherical and Plane Forms, 1998)vol.33(3),p.204).

To further find out the mathematical properties of the Sriyantra, I measured Sriyantras of different sizes and found similarity of

Table 1

Geometrical Shape	Dimension	Property	Perimeter	Area	Relationship
Circle	D= 8.2		25.748	52.78	Both major Up and down ▲ touch the circumference.
Up ▲ 1	6.5, 6.5, 8 Height = 5.12	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 52°	21	20.48	Pairing ;Kepler ▲ Ratio of side to half of the base is Phi (6.5/4=1.62) or the Golden Ratio. Two equal angles of 52° like in the pyramids.
Up ▲ 2	6,6,5.6 Height=5.3	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 62°	17.6	14.84	Highest triangle, pairing.
Up ▲ 3	4.8,4.8, 4 Height = 4.36	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 65°	13.6	8.72	Transaction with 3 rd & 5 th Down ▼ to create central equilateral ▼
Up ▲ 4	2.8,2.8,2.6 Height= 2.5	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 62°	8.2	3.25	pairing
Down ▼ 1	6.5, 6.5, 8 Height = 5.12	Isosceles triangles Two equal			Pairing, Kepler ▲,Ratio of side to half of the base is Phi (6.5/4=1.62) or the Golden

		angles of 52°			Ratio
Down ▼ 2	6,6,5.6 Height=5.3	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 62°	17.6	14.84	Highest triangle, pairing
Down ▼ 3	4, 4, 4.5 Height = 3.3	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 62°	12.5	9.675	Transaction. Non-isosceles side of Up ▲ becomes isosceles side of Down ▼
Down ▼ 4	2.8,2.8,2.6 Height= 2.5	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 65°	8.2	3.25	pairing
Down ▼ 5	1.5,1.5,1.8 Height= 1.2	Isosceles triangles Two equal angles of 52°	4.8	1.08	No pairing. Kepler ▲ Ratio of side to half of the base is Phi (6.5/4=1.62) or the Golden Ratio. Relationship with 10th self-arising Inner most ▼. Section of base becomes side of 10th ▲
Inner Most Triangle	0.75,0.75,0.75, Height = 0.7	Equilateral triangle All angles are 60°	2.25	0.2625	Each side is half of the smallest isosceles triangle viz. Down ▼ 5. The central downward ▼ is created by collinearity and intersection of Up ▲ 3, Down ▼ 3 and Down ▼ 5.

Table 2

Geometrical Shape	Dimension	Property	Perimeter	Area	Relationship
Circle	D= 19.6		61.54	301.56	
Up ▲ 1	15.6,15.6,19.4 Height = 12.2	Isosceles triangles	50.6	118.34	Pairing ; Ratio of isosceles side to half of the base is Phi (15.6/9.7=1.61) or the

					Golden Ratio
Up ▲ 2	14,14,13.6 Height= 12.24	Isosceles triangles	41.6	83.232	Highest triangle, pairing
Up ▲ 3	11.2,11.2,9.6 Height = 10.12	Isosceles triangles	32	48.57	Transaction with 3 rd & 5 th Down ▼ to create central equilateral ▼
Up ▲ 4	7,7, 6.4 Height = 6.22	Isosceles triangles	20.4	19.90	pairing
Down ▼ 1	15.6,15.6,19.4 Height = 12.2	Isosceles triangles	50.6	118.34	Pairing ; Ratio of isosceles side to half of the base is Phi (15.6/9.7=1.61) or the Golden Ratio
Down ▼ 2	14,14,13.6 Height= 12.24	Isosceles triangles	41.6	83.232	Highest triangle, pairing
Down ▼ 3	10.4,10.4,10.6 Height = 8.6	Isosceles triangles	12.5	9.675	Crude diagram. Transaction not seen. Non-isosceles side of Up ▲ has not exactly become isosceles side of Down ▼. Even height should be 8.95 as per trigonometric formulation, but actual height is 8.6cm.
Down ▼ 4	7,7, 6.4 Height = 6.22	Isosceles triangles	20.4	19.90	pairing
Down ▼ 5	4,4,4.6 Height= 3	Isosceles triangles	12.6	6.9	No pairing. Relationship with 10 th self-arising Inner most ▼
Inner Most Triangle	2,2,2, Height = 1.7	Equilateral triangle	6	1.7	Each side is half of the smallest isosceles triangle viz. Down

					▼5. The central downward ▼ is created by collinearity and intersection of Up ▲3, Down ▼3 and Down ▼5.
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Table 3

Geometrical Shape	Dimension	Property	Total Perimeter	Area	Relationship
Circle	D= 9.2		28.88	66.44	
Up ▲1	7.2,7.2, 8.8; Height = 5.7	Isosceles triangles	23.2	25.08	pairing , Ratio of side to half of the base is Phi($7.2/4.4=1.63$) or the Golden Ratio. Two equal angles of 52° like in the pyramids.
Up ▲2	6.6,6.6,6.4, Height=5.77	Isosceles triangles	19.06	18.464	Highest triangle, pairing
Up ▲3	5.4,5.4,4.6 Height = 4.7	Isosceles triangles	15.4	10.81	Transaction with 3 rd & 5 th Down ▼ to create central equilateral ▼
Up ▲4	3.2, 3.2, 3 Height= 2.8	Isosceles triangles	9.4	4.2	pairing
Down ▼1	7.2,7.2, 8.8; Height = 5.7	Isosceles triangles	24.2	25.08	Pairing, Ratio of side to half of the base is Phi($7.2/4.4=1.63$) or the Golden Ratio
Down ▼2	6.6,6.6,6.4, Height=5.77	Isosceles triangles	19.06	18.464	Highest triangle, pairing

Down ▼3	4.6, 4.6, 5 Height = 4	Isosceles triangles	14.2	10	Transaction. Non-isosceles side of Up ▲ becomes isosceles side of Down ▼
Down ▼4	3.2, 3.2, 3 Height= 2.8	Isosceles triangles	9.4	4.2	pairing
Down ▼5	1.7,1.7,2.1 Height= 1.34	Isosceles triangles	5.5	1.407	No pairing. Relationship with 10th self-arising Inner most ▼
Inner Most Triangle	0.85,0.85,0.85, Height = 0.73	Equilateral triangle	2.55	.57	Each side is half of the smallest isosceles triangle viz. Down ▼5. The central downward ▼ is created by collinearity and intersection of Up▲3, Down ▼3 and Down ▼5.

(Note: All measurement is in cm)

Based upon the induction, the properties of the Structure of the Sriyantra can be summarized as follow:

1. There are three primary triangles where phi property, as in pyramid, is found. These are the 1st Up, 1st Down and the 5th Down triangle.
2. The inner equilateral triangle is formed by the interaction between three triangles- 3rd Up, 3rd Down and the 5th Down.
3. Inner triangle shares the base with the 5th down triangle.
4. The transaction takes place at the level of 3rd Up and Down primary triangles.

The non-isosceles side of the Up triangle becomes the isosceles side of the down triangle.

5. All other triangles pair.
6. Even though all 9 triangles are isosceles, the inner most secondary triangle is equilateral.
7. Dimension of this equilateral triangle is half of the isosceles side of the unpaired 5th Down triangle. Thus, one can posit that the 5th Down primary triangle does pair with the inner equilateral triangle.
8. Tallest triangle is the 2nd Up and 2nd Down triangle.
9. The recursion in triangles appears to be geometric expression of Bronze Metallic

Mean property and same needs to be explored further.

TABLE 4: Metallic Mean Family in Mathematics of Aesthetics

Beyond Golden Mean: The World of Metallic Mean - Vera W.D. Spinadel(1929 – January 26, 2017)- Theory of Metallic Means by generalizing Golden Mean. - Metallic Mean as solution of quadratic equation $x^2 - px - q = 0$. Generalized equation of Mean is $\Phi_p = (p + \sqrt{p^2 + 4}) / 2$				
Value of p,q	Value of X	Numerical Value	Metallic Mean	Number Series
p=1,q=1	$\Phi = (1 + \sqrt{5}) / 2$	1.618	Golden Mean	1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21, 34, 55, 89, 144 Fibonacci Series
P=2, q=1	$1 + \sqrt{2}$	2.414	Silver Mean	1, 2, 5, 12, 29, 70, 169 Pell Series
P=3,q=1	$(3 + \sqrt{13}) / 2$	3.302	Bronze Mean	1, 1, 4, 13, 43, 142 Bronze Fibonacci
P=1,q=2	2	2	Copper Mean	1, 1, 3, 5, 11, 21, 43, 85
P=1,q=3	$(1 + \sqrt{13})/2$	2.302	Nickel Mean	1, 1, 4, 7, 19, 40, 97,
P=4,q=1	$(2 + \sqrt{5})$	4.236		1,1,5,25,125,625,3125
P=4,q= -1	$2 + \sqrt{3}$	3.732	Diamond mean	Found in Hofstadter butterfly, the geometrical shape of quantum system.

Phi Φ with an uppercase P is 1.618; and its close relative, phi with a lowercase p, ϕ is .618. Both are a form of the golden ratio.

The square root of Phi (1.6180339887...) = 1.2720196495... When 4 is divided by 1.2720196495... i.e. $\sqrt{\Phi}$, one obtains $\pi = 3.14460551103...$

This can be written as follow:

$$4 \div \sqrt{\Phi} \sim \pi$$

Thus, the structure of Sriyantra, though does not have direct connection with another significant number, π , it does contain the three

triangles with phi ration and thus, indirectly contains Pi property.

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(Niraj Kumar is the student of Nalanada Tradition. His forthcoming work is on *Nalanda Tradition*)



Travelogue: Southern Sojourn (Part I)

Dr. Girdharilal Kaw

In early July this year one of my friends suggested that we take a South India tour during Diwali vacations. After a little search and research on the net we decided to visit Tamil Nadu and Pondicherry (now called Puduchery) as well as Tirupati shrine . We checked a few tour programmes offered by various travel agencies and finally decided on one South Indian tour of eight days with Veena World tours of Mumbai, starting from 15th October.

Thus on a cloudy Sunday morning of 15th October we, the four of us boarded the early morning flight from Ahmedabad to Chennai and landed there at 8.15 am. The tour manager was waiting for us at the exit gates along with the eight other members with whom he had travelled from Mumbai about half an hour earlier. At the airport we boarded the company bus and proceeded for Kanchipuram. We were informed that it is a 75km ride which would take one and a half hour j to reach our destination. A working breakfast was served in the bus. Chennai was also heavily overcast but it was not raining, though the weather forecast was for a heavy rainfall there. The roads were reasonably good but only single track which became very congested in villages and towns. We reached Kanchipuram or Kanchi at 10.30am and drove straight to hotel Regency which was

located in the centre of the main market of the city. Before we checked in, we were informed by the tour manager, Mr.Vimesh Gohil that we could avail the time up to lunch hour for shopping and in the afternoon we would be going for sightseeing. Kanchi is famous for its silk sarees throughout India, and therefore all of us knew what the shopping here meant for women folk. Soon, all of us were roaming in the market and searching for big brand names of silk sarees. Within two hours we, along with stuffed bags of merchandise, reached our hotel rooms and took a little rest before we were called for lunch. It was a decent star hotel with continental and Indian dishes on the offer. After lunch, we took rest for some time and at sharp 3.30pm we were at the reception to embark on sightseeing.

Kanchi is no doubt famous for its silks in all of India but it is known as the city of temples throughout the world. The local legend is that it is one of the seven sacred cities or Mokshapuries of India, and second only to Varanasi in importance. The city has been the capital of Pallava kings from 6th to 8th century. The city was afterwards ruled by Cholas, Pandyas and Vijaynagara kings. Most of the important temples have been built during Pallava rule, though they were later renovated and extended by Chola, Pandya etc. kings.. Once the city had been an important learning centre of all the Indian religions like Shaivism, Vaishnavism, Jainism and Buddhism as well. The famous Chinese traveler, XUAN ZANG (Huan sang of Kashmir fame) visited the city around 640A.D. and has written about the glory of this great city. The city also boasts of being the head quarter of the Kanchi Matha of Adi-Shankara.

Our tour manager decided to start from Shiva Kanchi Temple, also known as Shri Ekambareshwara temple. This is the most famous temple in the city with an area of 24 acres and four great entrance gates called as Gopurams. The south Gopuram is the tallest one

at 192ft. After entering into the temple complex one reaches the main mandapa which is a thousand pillared structure, and each pillar is intricately and exquisitely carved. The local legend is that once Parvati came to Kanchi and made a Shivlinga of mud on the river bank under the shade of a mango tree, to worship Shiva, who had got annoyed with her at that time. Again, Shiva caused the river to overflow and burst on the banks, but Parvati sheltered the Shiv-lingam in such a way that no harm was done to it, which pleased Shiva and thus the shrine came into the existence.



Our next destination was Sri Kamakshi Amman temple, where the Goddess Kamakshi is worshipped as a sacred shakti-Peetam. According to South Indian belief the Goddess Parvati manifests in three forms on this planet i.e. as Kamakshi at Kanchi; as Meenakshi at Madhurai and as Vishalakshi at Varanasi. This temple is associated with Adi-Shankara, though the present structure was built in 14th century by Chola kings. The main temple is crowned with a gold plated vimanam. The deity called as Parabrahma Swarupini is in a seated position with Shri-Chakra in front, which is offered archana by devotees. As with other main temples, there are four entrance gates or Gopurams which are excellent examples of stone carving and sculpturing.



From there we went to Vishnu Kanchi temple also known as Sri Varadaraja Perumal temple. This is one of the most important temples of Vaishnavites. Legend has that Brahma was given the special Darshana of Chaturbuja Vishnu here after he performed penance and worship in the form of Ashwamedha Yagyam. The temple is famous for its massive and majestic super structure of a large construction with exquisite sculptures. A large mandap (Hall) with hundreds of pillars constructed during Vijaynagara Empire is worth seeing. Every pillar has intricate carvings but the corner pillars are unique in that the carving and sculpting in a single stone has four dimensional motifs in rings. The holy tank called Pushkarni houses the idol of Varadaraja under water and is taken out only once in forty years for darshana of devotees. In the main temple complex the deity of Lord is in a standing posture facing west. The temple is associated with Sri Ramanuja, who is supposed to have served here for a long time. One peculiar and interesting ritual performed here during the darshana is to touch the statues of two lizards carved in the ceiling and covered in gold and silver plates. Along with lizards there are sculptures of sun and moon on the ceiling. One has to climb a staircase to reach the ceiling and touch the sun, moon, golden lizard and silver lizard in that order for the complete ritual to get absolved of all the doshas or sins.



After leaving the temple complex we again indulged in shopping till late in the evening in a large and well endowed store called Ganpati Silks. Thus our first day of the tour ended on a jubilant note and we were back at hotel for dinner and night halt. Every evening our tour manager would inform us about the detailed programme of the next day and the exact time when we should be ready to leave the hotel.

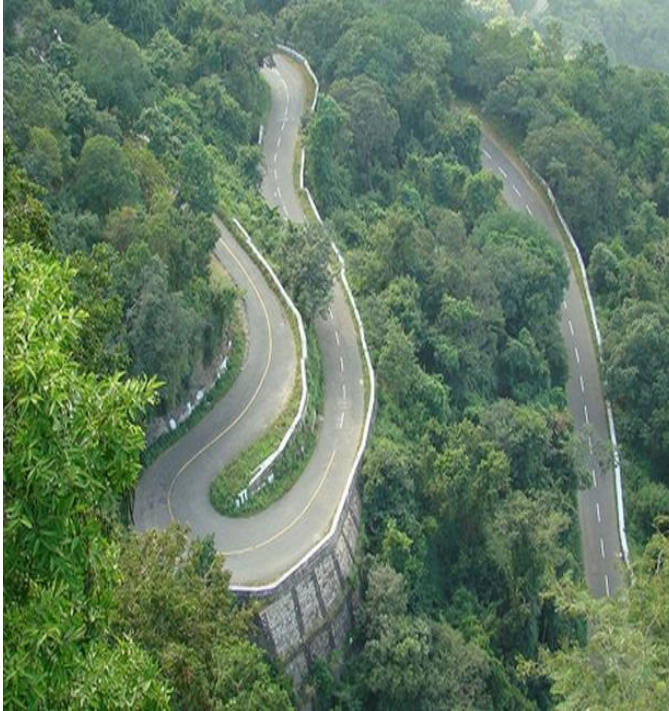
Next day i.e. on 16th October we were ready to leave at sharp 8am. We planned to visit Tirupati temple. Sky was overcast but it did not rain anywhere. The roads were again single track, congested and rough too. But surprisingly as soon as we crossed to Andhra-Pradesh road started getting better and the last 40 to 50 kms were four lane highways. With all that it took a little more than three hours to cover a distance of 110 kms. Tirumala city was very busy but with good roads and better cleanliness. We checked in at Fortune Kincet hotel and soon after we left for the Padamavati Temple. This is a temple of Goddess Laxmi, situated almost in the midst of the city. There are many interesting and hilarious stories about Padmavati (a form of Laxmi), along with Lord Vankateshwara, which I shall not dilate upon here. It was a smaller

temple and not very busy and we could have Darshanas very easily and almost quickly.



We returned to our hotel by 1.30pm for lunch and a short nap. At 3.30pm we were ready to leave for the world famous Tirupati Mandir. Our tourist bus would not be allowed to ply on the road to Temple. The tour manager arranged for a Tempo traveler and a taxi for this purpose. We were told that it is a distance of about 25kms and may take almost an hour, and then for darshana it may be anything from four to six hours in the queue. Thus, with such mental preparation we started at 3.30pm, and after passing through the city we reached the first traffic police post of the road to temple. Here besides the payment of toll charges all the security checks of the vehicles as well as the devotees were completed in few minutes only and we started a 23 km uphill drive. The road was very wide, one way and smooth, though winding as it travels up the hill. But more than anything else the green and dense vegetation on both sides of the road made a memorable site. A good winding hilly road with well kept lush green forests on both sides transpires a soothing and serene effect. There was a separate covered footpath also on one side for the people who tread this distance on foot due to mere devotion. Within exact forty minutes we were on the top of the hill and near about the entrance of the temple complex. We came to know of the strict traffic rules and speed control measures for driving. This distance of about 22kms has necessarily to be covered in 40 minutes as the traffic check posts at its both ends will check

the timings and defaulters are heavily fined. It applies on both sides. Moreover the roads going to Temple and return are separate, but both are equally beautiful, well maintained and of the same distance.



The temple complex today is a very vast and well kept place on the top of the Seshachalam hills, which are supposed to have seven peaks corresponding to seven heads of SheshaNag. The temple is dedicated to Lord Vankateshwara- an Autara of Vishnu. Vankateshwara is also known by the names of Balaji, Govind and Srinivasa. The first temple is thought to have been built in 300 AD, though it was extended, repaired and endowed with wealth and jewels by later kings and rulers. The present day structure has been built in 8th century by King Thondiaman- a Tamil ruler. Afterwards Pallavas of Kanchi in 9th AD, Cholas of Thanjavur in 10th century, Pandyas of Madurai in 12th century and Vijaynagara kings in 14-15 century improved and extended the premises to a large extent. The contribution of Krishnadevaraya of Vijayanagra is hailed as the most generous and substantial. The gold gilding of the main temple and endowments of various jewels and ornaments in a large quantity and overall patronization of the temple are remarkable.



At present the vast complex consists of the main temple, queue complex buildings along with covered sheds for devotees in the queue, Annapurna building for making prasadam, hair tonsure buildings and other lodging sites. This whole complex is run by a trust namely (TTD) Tirupati Devasthanam very efficiently. The garbha graha or sanctum sanctorum of the temple is called Anand Nilayam. The deity of the Lord Vankateshwara is in a standing position facing east. There are three entrances or Gopurams to the main temple. The main mahadwaram or Gopuram is fifty feet tall structure with wonderful sculptures. Two dwarapalas or gatekeepers namely Jay and Vijay are sculpted on the two sides of the main gate. The Prasadam building is a huge structure where world famous Tirupati Ladoos are prepared in bulk every day to be distributed among devotees. Another structure is used for Head Tonsuring where devotees offer their hair to the Lord. This ceremony also has a very interesting story behind it. Now-a-days it is a source of income also for the management as almost a ton of hair is offered every day here. This hair gets sorted out in various categories and then most of it is exported, earning about six million dollars per year. In the Garbha Greha Idol of the Lord bears Laxmi on the right chest and Padamavati on left chest. The idol is supposed to be a Swayambhu creation.

Once we entered the queue complex, we were surprised to see that it was not a very busy day. The lines were moving continuously, albeit at a slow pace. The average number of devotees in a day is supposed to be anywhere between sixty thousands to one lakh. On some special auspicious days it touches even three lakhs to

five lakhs. That day probably there were only twenty to thirty thousand devotees, the reason for the same got revealed to us after two days. There is again a security check post of the temple authorities, where your passport or Aadhar card in original is checked. Overall in about less than two hours we had completed the darshanas and then after having a stroll around the whole complex we returned through another, but similarly picturesque road to our hotel in the city.

Next day i.e. on 17th October, we were ready to leave the hotel at 8am. We planned to travel to Tiruchirapillai, often known as Trichy. To our surprise we were travelling back towards Kanchipuram and then after there further south to the city of Trichy. Thus we had to face again the same small and congested bad roads, at least up to Kanchi. Thereafter road was a bit better. At about 12.30pm we stopped at a roadside Restaurant for Lunch. The place was quite big, reasonably clean and calm. We were told that we will be served a traditional south Indian meal and thus there is no luxury of ordering or choosing. After waiting for about half an hour, we were served the food in pre-filled huge thallies containing seventeen small vatkis with many unidentifiable vegetables and other concoctions. Rice was served in four varieties each with a different color. Needless to say, it was a memorable experience and tasty too. After lunch, just outside the restaurant we saw few shops of handicrafts and one factory outlet of Cotton Street. Just out of curiosity, we entered the shop to see the merchandise. To my surprise cotton apparels of many varieties were of very quality material, that too at very genuine prices. We could not resist buying a few things and on the enquiry about the raw material etc we were told that most of their apparel is manufactured for export, and this being a factory outlet prices are quite low.

Soon we started our journey southwards, and our tour manager informed us that we are visiting a small place in the way called Samaya Puram, where we shall see an ancient Durga

temple. It was a small village and the temple was virtually in the centre of the residential area. When we proceeded towards the temple we were told that the main entrance gate is under renovation and we had to enter through a small gate. It was a small but ancient temple with an impressive image of Mother Goddess. What was more wonderful about the place, that it was almost empty with no other visitor except our group. On enquiry we came to know that in Tamil Nadu Diwali was to be celebrated on 18th only i.e. on fourteenth day of dark fortnight and not on Amavasya. And people usually will not visit the temples for three days of Diwali from Dhanteras onwards.



After Darshana and mid day tea etc we proceeded to Trichy and we reached the city around 6pm. We went straight for the world famous Ranganathanswamy Temple. On reaching there we were told that the main temple shall open at 7pm only. But almost one hour of time was well spent in just looking at the Southern Gopuram of the temple. The temple is dedicated to Ranganatha- a form of Vishnu, and is counted among the 108 Divya Desams dedicated to Vishnu in India with very rich legend and history. The temple complex is situated on the banks of river Kaveri, rather on an island of the river. The main Gopuram or the Dakshina Gopuram is an awe inspiring, and majestic architectural marvel. It stands 236 feet tall i.e. a more than twenty stories stone structure with exquisite carvings and sculpting. It is almost pyramidal in shape standing on base

of about 9000 square feet. Unfortunately it was getting dark and we could not take even good photographs of the structure. The temple complex is spread on 158 acres of area which makes it the largest functioning Hindu temple in the world, the other one in Cambodia is Angkor Wat Temple which is larger but it is not a functioning temple right now. There are legends galore about such an important place which connect the temple with Lord Rama. But archeological evidence of its main temple being built in 9th century is overwhelming. There are inscriptions from Chola, Pandyas, Hoysala and Vijaynagara kings in the complex. There is an interesting story about the main idol- a Reclining Vishnu- which is exquisitely beautiful and mesmerizing, to say the least. After the Muslim invasion, Malik Kafur in 1311AD took the statue to Delhi to the dismay of all the devotees. Some of the artistic devotees went to Delhi and performed some unusual histrionics and feats which pleased the Emperor, who was ready to grant them any gift. That time these people asked for the deity which was granted. Meanwhile emperor's daughter Surathani had fallen in love with the idol and followed him to Trichy, and she is supposed to have got the Nirvana in front of the idol only. There is a shrine in her name near Arjun Mandapa having an ancient but beautiful painting of hers. Temple has seven major Gopurams and fourteen other smaller ones. A thousand pillared Mandapam built by Vijayanagar kings is a sight to see. Each Pillar is having fantastic carvings of leaping animals, wildly racing horses bearing riders on their backs and trampling tigers by their hoofs. There are some smaller mandapas called Sesa Mandapam, Garuda mandapam, Killi Mandapam. Ramanujacharya is supposed have got his divinity here, after he wrote his Bhashyam over Gita explaining his Vishisht-Advaita philosophy.

Here again it was not very busy, and we were lucky to be able to see all mandapas, all Gopurams, main Temple and surrounding structures almost at ease. The final Darshana of the Lord in the reclining posture in the garbha Greha was an exhilarating experience. The idol

is made of jet black granite with such artistic finesse that one really feels blessed. The Lord Vishnu is called here as Vardharaja also. Just near the reclining deity a smaller idol of Vishnu in a sitting posture adorned with many ornaments and flowers was also seen. Just near the sanctum-sanctorum, rather a little ahead of it a small but beautiful temple of Laxmi was shown to us. Here Laxmi is flanked by Krishna and Narsimha. The whole entourage of the complex finished late at about 8.40pm and we left for the hotel straight from here. The HighPoint Hotel was the part of a huge shopping mall- the whole of fourth floor- a modern luxurious hotel. The management welcomed us in a very traditional way, as it was the Diwali eve in Tamil Nadu. We were offered pearl garlands, Kumkum tilaks and sweets. The rooms as well as service also were excellent

To be Continued

(Dr G.L Kaw is a medical practitioner based in Gandhinagar Gujarat with an avid interest in history, philosophy, classical Sanskrit and Persian literature)

Sacred Lodge for Beloveds

~ Ambika Talwar



Sacred lodge cannot be dimmed
by a passing glance, but for a cosmic moment
desires arise — well water's pure stream
sings through fire rising mist in valleys.

Songs that have lain low lift as tho' heaven
were no ceiling but pages scrambled
with music of love that cools the fire
and heats it up streaming into our hearts.

Where sacred lore weaves its *nadís*
into Gaia's arteries, heaven awakens
for lovers have resided amid broken rocks.

Wherever Sati's body pieces were thrown
is a temple to Mother; each particle we breathe
is temple of Her limbs, eyes, *nabhí*, *yoni*

her *píthas* are splendid cushions of rock
Rest here in your *sufferings*... Place of refuge.

Grace that delights is not lost in the sanctum:
bee-hives are woven with hearts, hands, hair
eyes of dove, deer, pelican, eagle, peacock,
remind us again how circles entwining *hum-sa*
open doors so we may never be lost.

Blow your breath into my breath! Be a crucible.
Wink madly as if intoxicants knew no way out.

Sing wildly! Let winds circle madly
call loudly madly for Ma. How can she ignore
her own longing for rivers to curl on our palms?

Oh Heart! Be endless doors Invisible
and indivisible as eternal Beloved

Varanasi – Luminous City

Banks of ancient Ganga sing of before and after life;
ash and saffron flowers float, syllables sink to river
bottom amid silent wailing, ripples passing by.

One hundred meters away, funeral pyres release
violent flames, which disappear into crows' azure.
Thus legends lie still or vanish, but story of Shiva
is endless even if partly forgotten. Memory needs
not quietude... walls are gouache of spit images.

Daily bathers cross the river, dip in its cold currents
as I did one winter morning with my father, while
mother and companions watched from a little boat
rocking in its karmic rhythm, stories of scriptures.

Sangam of Varuna and Assi, Shiva's luminous city calls
golden time of respectful order to lift us out from
granular confines, bitter nuance of broken columns,
houses of fussed music, sweet aroma of betel leaves,
as heart-full romance of beaten souls wander.

I write these words: city streets winding as mothers
in rags ache for fulfillment, not lost in hunger
nor destitute as mountains strip-mined of essence,

as rivers sinking into oblivion, as plants whose sap
forgotten lingers in glance of Mother's tears. Ghajini
posters on walls, and cows die for plastic foods.

Despite this shattering, Varanasi smiles, sentiments
like incense swirls rises into clouds calling rain
in spring. May these be woven in silk, for gentle curves
of Parvati's bruised shoulders under an old banyan tree.

Bones of the burning dead float freely in fast currents.
Do not drink this water! Let dead dreams dissolve.
into liberation. Let them not haunt the living...!

(Ambika Talwar is an author, healer, teacher and an artist and is currently teaching English in Cypress College)

Photo Feature on Temples of Cambodia

Deepak Kaw



ANGKOR WAT



ANGKOR WAT



ANGKOR WAT COMPLEX



BANTEAY KDEI



BAYON

**BAYON****TA PHROM**



NEAK POAN



PRAE ROUP



ANGKOR WAT COMPLEX

(Deepak Kaw is an architect by profession, an enthusiast photographer and avid traveller)



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